



AN ESSAY

The Thought Is Not The Truth.

*On the discovery, made later than it should be, that the
voice running our thoughts is not us.*

BY TARAN

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The Thought Is Not The Truth.

Sit somewhere quiet for two minutes, and try not to think. See what happens.

Within seconds, your mind starts. A meeting. A comment someone made yesterday. The email you forgot to send. The way someone looked at you. The thoughts arrive on their own, uninvited, and most of us follow them down whatever path they want to take us. We don't choose them. We obey them.

Have you ever stopped to ask whether the thoughts in your head are actually telling you the truth?

Most of us never do. We assume that whatever shows up in our mind is reporting reality. If the thought says *you're not enough*, we feel not enough. If the thought says *this is going to go wrong*, we expect it to go wrong. The thought arrives. We take it as fact. We move through the day on it.

It's the most expensive assumption a person can make. And nobody warned us about it.

The thing nobody taught us

We are taught what to think for sixteen years. Math. History. Language. Science. We learn to compute compound interest and diagram a

sentence. Useful skills. None of them touched the operating system underneath. Nobody pulled us aside and said: by the way, the voice in your head is going to talk to you for the rest of your life. It will sound exactly like you. It will use your vocabulary. It will speak in the first person. And most of what it says will not be true.

"You have power over your mind, not outside events. Realize this, and you will find strength."

— MARCUS AURELIUS, MEDITATIONS, C. AD 170

That single sentence has carried longer than most empires. Aurelius was the emperor of Rome. He had every external power a person could have, and he wrote, in his private notebook to himself, that the only real one was the power over what happened inside his own head.

James Allen, in 1903, wrote a small book called *As a Man Thinketh*. The line that survives it, *"as a man thinketh in his heart, so is he,"* is more demanding than most people who quote it understand. Allen wasn't telling us to think positive thoughts. He was saying that whatever we repeat in our minds, we slowly become. Not in a season. Over years.

If both of those men were right, and they have been borne out across two thousand years of people testing the claim, then the thoughts running through your head right now matter more than almost anything else you'll do today.

So who is choosing them?

— The first time you notice

The first move is the smallest one anyone ever describes. You don't argue with the thought. You don't replace it. You don't push it away. You just notice it.

A thought arrives. You see it. You name it as quietly as you can. *Anxious. Critical. Comparing. Catastrophizing. Ashamed. Replaying.* The naming doesn't have to be elegant. The naming is the entire move.

Something quiet happens the first time you do this. The thought you noticed gets smaller. Not because you fought it. Because being seen is, for most thoughts, the end of their power. They run on the assumption that they are you. The moment you watch a thought happening in your mind, instead of being inside it, it loosens.

Think of it like this. You're in a room and someone is shouting at you. The shouting feels personal. Then you realize the shouting is coming from a speaker on the wall, playing on a loop. Same voice. Same words. But once you see the speaker, you stop reacting the way you were. You can hear it. You can decide whether to keep listening or whether to walk out of the room.

That's what noticing a thought is. The thought hasn't changed. Your relationship to it has.

When was the last time you actually watched a thought come and go, without acting on it?

For most of us, the honest answer is rarely or never. We've spent our whole lives inside the speaker.

— Why this is not positive thinking

This is the part most people misread on the first try. The practice is not about telling yourself nicer things. It's not affirmations. It's not pushing the dark thought away and replacing it with a lighter one. That move is its own kind of trap, because the dark thought always comes back, and you spend your life in a tug of war you can't win.

The work is more honest than that. You see the thought. You name it. You ask whether it's actually true. Then you decide whether to act on it.

Most thoughts, examined directly, do not survive the question. The catastrophe scenario your mind is rehearsing has not happened. The verdict it's delivering on you is not based on evidence. It's based on a belief installed years ago that you have never audited. The comparison it's running between you and someone else is selective and unfair to both of you.

You don't have to defeat these thoughts. You just have to stop assuming they are telling you the truth.

— A practice, not a technique

There is no graduating from this. The thoughts keep arriving. The mind keeps producing. The work is being the one who notices, every day, for the rest of your life.

Meditation is one of the oldest containers for this practice. Two and a half thousand years of various traditions, from the Buddha onwards, arrived at the same conclusion: most of what runs through a human mind is noise, and the practice of sitting quietly and watching the noise without joining it is the foundational act of self-governance. You can do

it for ten minutes a day without believing in any of the metaphysics around it. The mechanism works regardless.

If you've never tried any of this, here's the only instruction that matters. For the next seven days, don't change anything about your life. Don't try to think differently. Don't try to feel differently. Just notice the thoughts as they arrive. When you catch one, name it as quietly and accurately as you can. *Critical. Anxious. Comparing. Ashamed. Replaying.* That's the practice. That is the entire practice.

What do you think you'd find by the end of seven days, if you actually did it?

For most people, what they find is more space between themselves and their mind than they knew was possible. Not because anything has changed. Because they've stepped, for the first time, into the only seat in the house that was always available to them, and that nobody had ever pointed out.

The thought is not the truth. The thought is not the verdict. The thought is not you.

That single recognition, sustained, is the doorway to almost every kind of clarity worth having. Allen knew it. Aurelius knew it. Confucius pointed at the same thing when he wrote that life is really simple, but we insist on making it complicated. The traditions that have survived across centuries know it. The reason the recognition has to be made personal, by every person, in their own time, on their own, is because no one else can make it for us.

What's one thought, today, you could let pass without believing it?

— TARAN



A note on this piece.

This is the first essay in a small library of pieces I am writing on the mind, on the older traditions of thinking, and on the long arc of building a life. They are published when finished, not on a schedule. Each one takes one idea and tries to render it as cleanly as it can be.

If anything here was useful, more pieces will appear at taranaujla.ca in their time. If not, leave it.

The depth is in the work, not in the surface.

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